



Acceptance Criteria

The Rules of the Game

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TL;DR

User Stories describe the *Dream*. Acceptance Criteria describe the *Reality*.

They are the specific conditions that must be met for a feature to be marked "Done."

No AC = No Testing.

The Core Definition

Think of Acceptance Criteria as a **Contract**.

It is an agreement between the Product Owner (Business) and the Team (Dev & QA).

- **For Developers:** It tells them what to build.
- **For QAs:** It tells us exactly what to test.
- **For Stakeholders:** It guarantees they get what they asked for.

The Golden Rule:

AC must be **Binary** (Pass/Fail).

-  Vague: "The upload should be fast." (How fast?)
 -  Clear: "The upload must complete in under 2 seconds." (Yes or No).
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The Two Common Formats

1. Rule-Oriented (Simple List)

Just a bulleted list of constraints. Best for UI changes or simple logic.

- "Button must be blue."
- "Password must be 8 characters."

2. Scenario-Oriented (Gherkin / BDD)

Uses the **Given / When / Then** format. Best for complex logic and flows.

- **Given** I am on the Login Page,
 - **When** I enter a valid password,
 - **Then** I should be redirected to the Dashboard.
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Real World Example: The "Promo Code" Field

User Story: "As a user, I want to enter a promo code so I can get a discount."

Format 1: Rule-Based AC

- The code must be case-insensitive (TEST = test).
- If the code is expired, show error: "This code has expired."
- Only one code can be applied per order.
- The discount cannot reduce the total below \$0.

Format 2: Scenario-Based AC (Gherkin)

Scenario: Applying a valid code

- **Given** I have \$100 in my cart
 - **And** I have a 10% off code "SAVE10"
 - **When** I apply the code
 - **Then** the total should become \$90
 - **And** a success message "Code Applied" is shown.
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Why This Matters

Ambiguity is the enemy of Quality.

If the AC is missing or vague, the Developer guesses, and the Tester guesses. Usually, they guess differently, and we end up with a bug.

Clear AC prevents "Opinion Wars."